

The German military also began attempts in earnest, creating “Fish” ciphers, and finally invented the world’s first ever programmable computer, the Colossus, in aid of cryptanalysis.

Finally, America created the MI-8 in 1917, a unit dedicated to cryptanalysis. This organization analysed all secret messages, links and codes. This was largely successful after WW I but in 1929, it was decided to have it shut down as it was found inappropriate to “read others’ mail”. An American couple, William Fredrick Friedman and his wife, Elizabeth Smith were a famous couple in cryptography, having devised new methods to solve ciphers through frequency counts and superimposition.

Codes in words

A lot of literature is the perfect foil for cryptography. Take Edgar Allen Poe’s cryptographic uses, for example. He used many systematic methods to decipher in the 1840s. He also went on to advertise his abilities in the Philadelphia paper Alexander’s Weekly (Express) Messenger and invited ciphers to be submitted, of which he solved almost all. Poe wrote a comprehensive essay which was quite handy for amateur British cryptanalysts who were involved in breaking German ciphers during World War I. That apart, ciphers played a vital role in his famous story, “The Gold-Bug”.



Raphael's Sistine Madonna
(c. 1513-1514)

Arthur Canon Doyle’s Sherlock Holmes also used simple ciphers to solve several mysteries. When a cipher was delivered to Holmes, he used the Almanac as the “codebook” to decipher the message.

The earliest and most famous of literal ciphers were described by Sir Francis Bacon. The bilateral cipher uses two fonts,

one ordinary and the other specially cut. The difference between these two fonts is so minute that it can only be noted through a powerful magnifying glass. Initially, italics were used to communicate but being more ornate; they offered a perfect disguise for the plaintext.

Shakespeare’s four folios use this cipher throughout the text, where almost entire scenes have been added. The bilateral cipher was not just